

Hypertension (High Blood Pressure): General Information

What is hypertension?

Hypertension means blood pressure that stays higher than the healthy range. Blood pressure is written as two numbers, systolic over diastolic, for example 120/80 mmHg. Hypertension usually has no symptoms, so it is sometimes called a silent condition.

Blood pressure categories

In general, normal blood pressure is below 120/80 mmHg. Elevated is a systolic number of 120 to 129 with a diastolic number below 80. Stage 1 hypertension is 130 to 139 systolic or 80 to 89 diastolic. Stage 2 hypertension is 140/90 or higher. A diagnosis requires repeated readings and professional assessment.

Risk factors

Common risk factors for hypertension include older age, family history, excess body weight, low physical activity, a diet high in salt, heavy alcohol use, tobacco use, ongoing stress, and some other health conditions.

Lifestyle measures

Lifestyle measures that help lower blood pressure include eating more fruits, vegetables and whole grains, reducing sodium (salt) intake, staying physically active, keeping a healthy weight, limiting alcohol, avoiding tobacco, and managing stress and sleep.

Why it matters

Untreated high blood pressure increases the risk of heart attack, stroke, heart failure, kidney disease and vision problems. Regular blood pressure checks allow early detection and follow-up with a healthcare professional.

Symptoms needing urgent care

Very high blood pressure together with severe headache, chest pain, shortness of breath, confusion, vision changes or weakness on one side of the body can be an emergency. Anyone with these symptoms should seek emergency care immediately.